

# From Findings to Policy

Module 2 · Day 4, Session 2: Evidence Translation

3ie

# 0 • The decision

## From reading evidence to writing it

This morning you judged whether a report was credible. Now someone hands you findings you did not produce and asks what the authority should do. For many of you that is the usual request.

**The last time you wrote up evidence for a decision, what was the hardest part?**

## The programme

|                   |                                                               |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Programme</b>  | Tariff Shield                                                 |
| <b>What it is</b> | A fuel-price stabilisation scheme for small freight operators |
| <b>Where</b>      | Abu Dhabi emirate                                             |
| <b>When</b>       | Piloted 2024–2026                                             |

This is **not** GreenWaste. It is a different scheme, and you have not seen these findings before.  
**Illustrative case, with invented figures.**

## The number the decision turns on

# 900

AED per vehicle per year, the threshold to clear

The evaluation was randomised, well executed and reported transparently. Nothing in it fails this morning's checklist.

[MENTI PLACEHOLDER] Would you recommend this scheme for rollout? Yes / No / Only with changes. Vote before reading the findings; you vote again at the end.



# 1 • The findings

## Six findings, all of them sound

### # Finding

- 1 Fuel costs fell for participating operators
- 2 The saving is real but smaller than the threshold
- 3 Freight rates fell slightly more for participating operators
- 4 Two-thirds of eligible operators did not join
- 5 The scheme's administration cost more than budgeted
- 6 No measurable effect on vehicle maintenance or fleet renewal

Every one survives this morning's checklist.

**If the evidence is sound, what makes the brief hard to write?**

## Finding 1: the saving

Fuel costs fell for participating operators. Net saving of **743 AED per vehicle per year** (95% CI: 690 to 796). Statistically significant at conventional levels.

|                  |                              |
|------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>Estimate</b>  | 743 AED per vehicle per year |
| <b>Interval</b>  | 690 to 796                   |
| <b>Threshold</b> | 900                          |

A clean, well-measured effect on the main outcome, from a randomised allocation. It is the finding the evaluation was designed to produce.

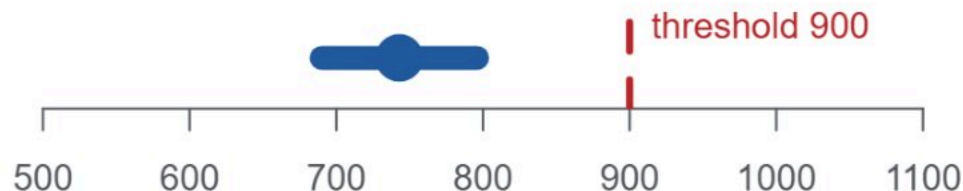
The whole interval lies below 900. On the authority's own rule, the scheme does not clear the bar.

## Finding 2: the same finding, read against the rule

Threshold (AED per vehicle)

900

`threshold_view(rule)`



Net saving, AED per vehicle per year

| threshold | shortfall | interval_clears |
|-----------|-----------|-----------------|
| 900       | 157       | FALSE           |

743 against 900: success or failure? Move the threshold: **where does the verdict flip, and who chose 900?**

The evaluation states the 157 AED shortfall plainly. It does not say whether 900 was the right threshold; nothing in it was designed to answer that.

## Finding 3: the pass-through

Freight rates charged by participating operators fell by an average of **1.8%**, against **0.4%** among non-participants. The difference is **not statistically significant** ( $p = 0.11$ ).

This is the finding most likely to end up in a brief. What would you write?

### **What the evidence supports**

Freight rates fell among participants, in the expected direction, and more than among non-participants.

### **What it does not**

That customers benefited. The estimate cannot be told apart from zero: it is a hypothesis the evaluation could not settle.

## Finding 4: who did not join

**34%** of eligible operators enrolled. Non-participants were more likely to be small fleets and to operate on fixed public-sector contracts.

The evaluation reports a pattern. Does it explain it?

No. It measured **who** did not join, not **why**. “Small operators did not take it up” is reportable. “Small operators could not take it up” is an inference the evidence does not support, and it points to a different recommendation.

## Finding 5: the cost of running it

Administration ran **22% over budget**. The overrun is concentrated in verification of fuel purchase records, which required manual inspection in **41%** of cases.

This figure comes from the scheme's own accounts, not from the impact estimate, and it bears most directly on whether to do this again.

It is also the finding most often left out of a brief, because it is about delivery rather than impact. If a brief recommends rollout without it, the authority finds out after deciding.

## Finding 6: the null result

No measurable effect on vehicle maintenance or fleet renewal. Point estimates for both outcomes are close to zero with **wide confidence intervals**. The evaluation cannot rule out effects of either sign.

How do you write a finding that says nothing was found, and is that a finding?

Yes, if you say what kind of result it is. The intervals are wide, so the study could have missed an effect that matters. "The evaluation could not detect an effect" is accurate; "the scheme had no wider benefits" overstates it.

## 2 • The brief

## Four elements, one page

| Element          | Length        | What it has to do                                                                                                          |
|------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Headline finding | 1 sentence    | One sentence, with the number in it, that a non-specialist would understand and would not misread.                         |
| Key implications | 2–3 sentences | Two or three sentences. What follows for the commissioning authority, given what the evaluation did and did not establish. |
| Recommendation   | 1 sentence    | One specific action. It must be something the authority can actually decide.                                               |
| One risk         | 1–2 sentences | The one thing most likely to make this recommendation wrong, stated so that it can be watched.                             |

One side of A4. Decision-makers rarely read past the first page.

## The headline sentence

Write your headline finding as **one sentence**, with the number in it. Then ask: if this were the only sentence anyone read, could they conclude the opposite of what you found?

### **The test**

A reader who stops after one sentence should not be able to reach a conclusion the evidence does not support.

“Fuel costs fell for participating operators” is true and easy to read, and it lets the reader assume the threshold was cleared. The number prevents that.

## Test your headline

R Code

↺ Start Over

▶ Run Code

```
1 headline <- "Fuel costs fell for participating operators."  
2 check_brief(headline)[1:2, ]
```

| check                        | result |
|------------------------------|--------|
| Gives the saving (743)       | NO     |
| States the 900 AED threshold | NO     |

Read me your headline. I type it between the quotes and press Run. A headline needs the first two checks; the rest apply to the whole brief.

## The recommendation

Your recommendation must be **one specific action** the authority can decide.

### Decidable

- Roll out to the three regions where the scheme was piloted
- Extend the pilot for two years and re-run the costing
- Do not roll out, and re-tender the verification process

### Not decidable

- The scheme should be improved
- More evidence is needed
- Stakeholders should be engaged

Which option can you defend, and does it depend on how you weigh 743 against 900?

## The risk

Name **one thing** that would make your recommendation wrong, stated so that it can be watched.

### **A risk you can watch**

"If the 22% cost overrun is repeated at scale, administration cost per vehicle would exceed the saving. The first two quarters of spending would show this."

### **A caveat presented as a risk**

"Results may not generalise." True of almost any evaluation; it can be neither confirmed nor watched.

## Write the brief

Pairs, twelve minutes, on the template: the headline with its number, two or three implications, one recommendation, one risk you can watch.

Keep the findings pack open. Every sentence in your brief should point to a finding.

## 3 · Pairs and critique

## Swap

Pairs, swap briefs. Read your partner's as the person deciding.

1. What does this brief want me to do?
2. What is its strongest claim, and does the findings pack support it?
3. What has it left out that I would have wanted to know?

Spend most of your time on question 3. What is missing is harder to spot than what is wrong.

## What to look for

1. Does the headline sentence contain the number?
2. Does it mention the 900 AED threshold at all?
3. Does it claim a customer benefit from the pass-through finding?
4. Does it explain why two-thirds did not enrol?
5. Does it mention the 22% cost overrun?
6. Does it turn the null finding into a statement of no effect?

Each is a way to write a brief that is accurate sentence by sentence and misleading as a whole.

## Run the checks on a draft

R Code

↺ Start Over

▶ Run Code

```
1 draft <- "Tariff Shield saved operators 743 AED per vehicle per year, short of the
2 900 AED threshold. Freight rates fell slightly, but the evaluation could not show
3 customers gained. Only 34% of eligible operators joined."
4 check_brief(draft)
```

| check                                   | result |
|-----------------------------------------|--------|
| Gives the saving (743)                  | yes    |
| States the 900 AED threshold            | yes    |
| Does not claim customers benefited      | yes    |
| Gives the enrolment figure (34%)        | yes    |
| Mentions the 22% cost overrun           | NO     |
| Does not turn the null into 'no effect' | yes    |

A volunteer pair reads out their brief; I paste it in and press Run. Which checks does it pass, and is the check right?

## The two failures that matter most

### **Omitting the threshold**

A brief that reports 743 and never mentions 900 lets the reader conclude the scheme met its target.

### **Omitting the cost overrun**

The authority is deciding whether to spend money. A brief about impact and not cost answers a different question from the one asked.

Both are omissions rather than errors. Which is harder to catch in your own draft?

## 4 • Put AI to work

## The prompt

Here are six findings from an evaluation of a fuel-price stabilisation scheme for small freight operators. Write a one-page policy brief for the commissioning authority with a headline finding, key implications, a recommendation, and one risk to flag.

It asks for what you were just asked to write. Read the draft, then edit it as a team.

## What came back

*A response like this is possible, especially with a short or leading prompt:*

**Headline finding.** The scheme reduced fuel costs for participating operators, **delivering a net saving of 743 AED per vehicle per year**. The result is statistically significant and the evaluation was rigorously conducted.

**Key implications.** Operators **passed part of the saving on to customers, with freight rates falling by 1.8%**, suggesting a wider economic benefit. **Some operators chose not to enrol**, which may indicate a need for better communication. **Recommendation.** Roll the scheme out more widely, with **targeted outreach to operators who did not participate**. **Risk to flag.** Results from a pilot may not generalise to a full rollout.

Find the four flagged problems.  
Then find the two things the draft leaves out entirely, which are not flagged.

## The checks, run on the AI draft

R Code [Start Over](#)

[Run Code](#)

```
1 ai_draft <- "The scheme reduced fuel costs for participating operators, delivering a
2 net saving of 743 AED per vehicle per year. Operators passed part of the saving on
3 to customers, suggesting a wider economic benefit. Some operators chose not to
4 enrol. The scheme should be rolled out more widely. Results may not generalise."
5 check_brief(ai_draft)
```

| check                                   | result |
|-----------------------------------------|--------|
| Gives the saving (743)                  | yes    |
| States the 900 AED threshold            | NO     |
| Does not claim customers benefited      | NO     |
| Gives the enrolment figure (34%)        | NO     |
| Mentions the 22% cost overrun           | NO     |
| Does not turn the null into 'no effect' | yes    |

It fails four of six: no threshold, a customer benefit it cannot show, no enrolment figure, no cost overrun. It overstated the good news and softened the bad. Check your own drafts, and any AI draft, for the same pattern.

## What AI did, and what it could not do

### What it did well

- The right four elements, in the right order
- The register of a brief
- One page, fluent enough to send unedited

### What it did not

- Never mentions the 900 threshold
- Calls a non-significant estimate a wider benefit
- Turns 34% enrolment into “some operators”
- Leaves out the 22% cost overrun
- Names a caveat, not a risk

## The same task, a better prompt

The same six findings. Before you write anything: first, list the findings that argue **against** rollout and how strongly each one argues, then those that argue for it. Second, tell me which finding would have to be different for your recommendation to change, and in which direction. Then write the brief, including a sentence that states plainly what the evaluation did not establish.

Three changes: ask for **the case against first**, so it is not an afterthought; ask **what would change the recommendation**, which brings the threshold in; and require a statement of **what was not established**, which makes omission harder.

5 · Close

## Vote again

# 900

The bar, and 743 sits below it

[MENTI PLACEHOLDER] Same three options: Yes / No / Only with changes. Compare the two votes. If they moved, was it the threshold that moved them?



## What makes a brief trustworthy

1. The number is in the headline sentence, not buried in the body.
  2. The threshold the number is judged against is stated, even when it is missed.
  3. Findings that argue against the recommendation are named, not left out.
  4. The recommendation is an action the reader can take or refuse.
  5. The risk is something that could happen and could be watched.
  6. What the evaluation did not establish is stated as plainly as what it did.
- Which of the six is hardest to write when you already know the recommendation you want?

## Next session

The last session of the module. You take the evaluation design you started in Module 1 and add to it: how you would present results, cost the programme, show the figures and translate the findings. Then a five-minute pitch, with feedback. Bring your notes from the week.